

Adventures in Trabuco Canyon – The Search For Miner Gold

After some previous near mishaps with my old AMS coworkers we have started doing more and more off trail explorations in the mountains behind where I live. This means making our way through dense vegetation to get to areas where few others have been.



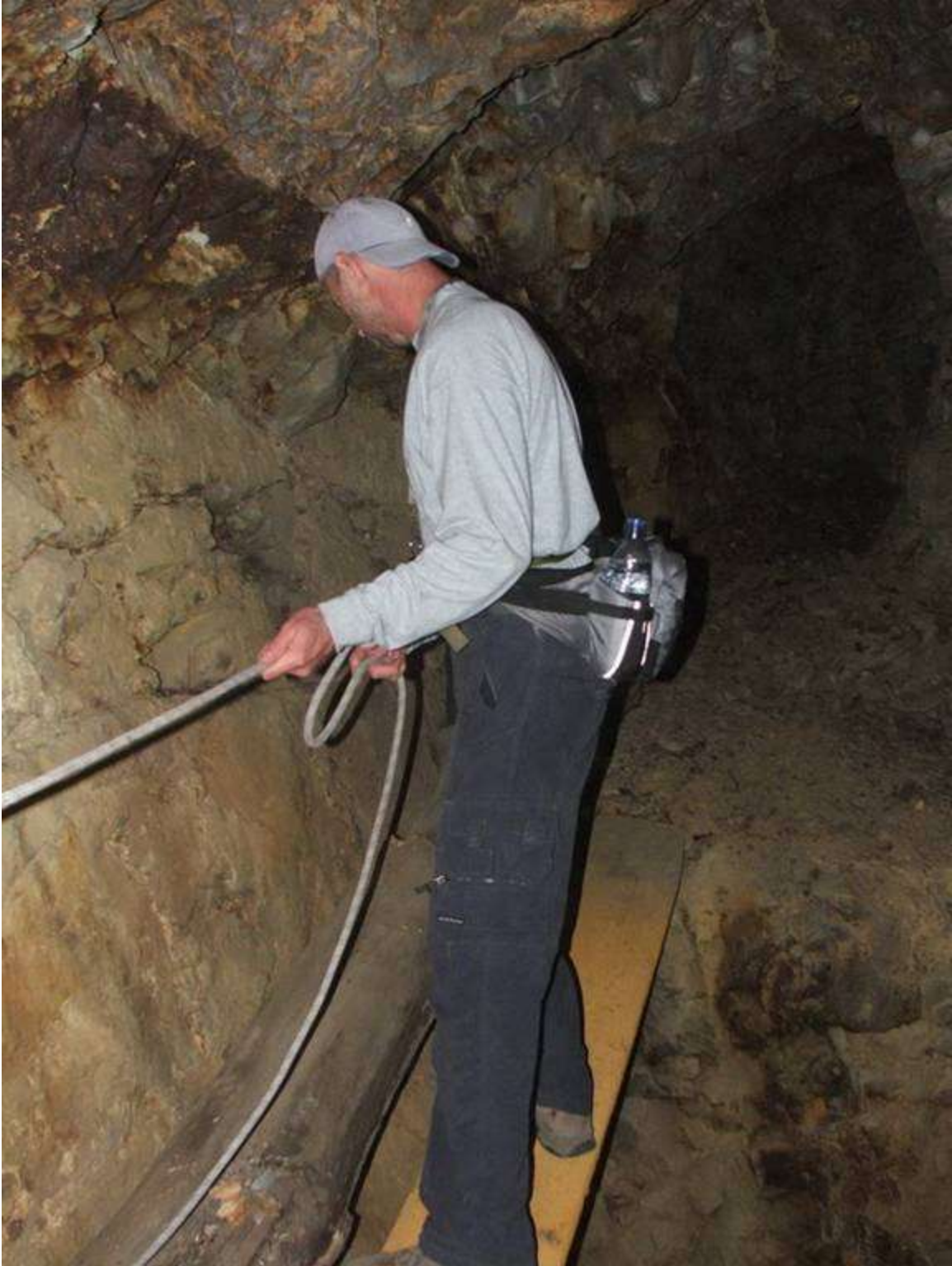
This is a view from the canyon wall of the area we like to hike. It's a nice change from some of the more desert-like areas around here.



This was the goal for this particular hike; an unmarked mine entrance quite a ways from any trail. We found it by accident during a previous exploration.



This is the view inside. It was very clearly manmade with the braces and the big square vertical drop by the entrance (not visible here.) To the right of this picture it looked like the mine continued beyond view.

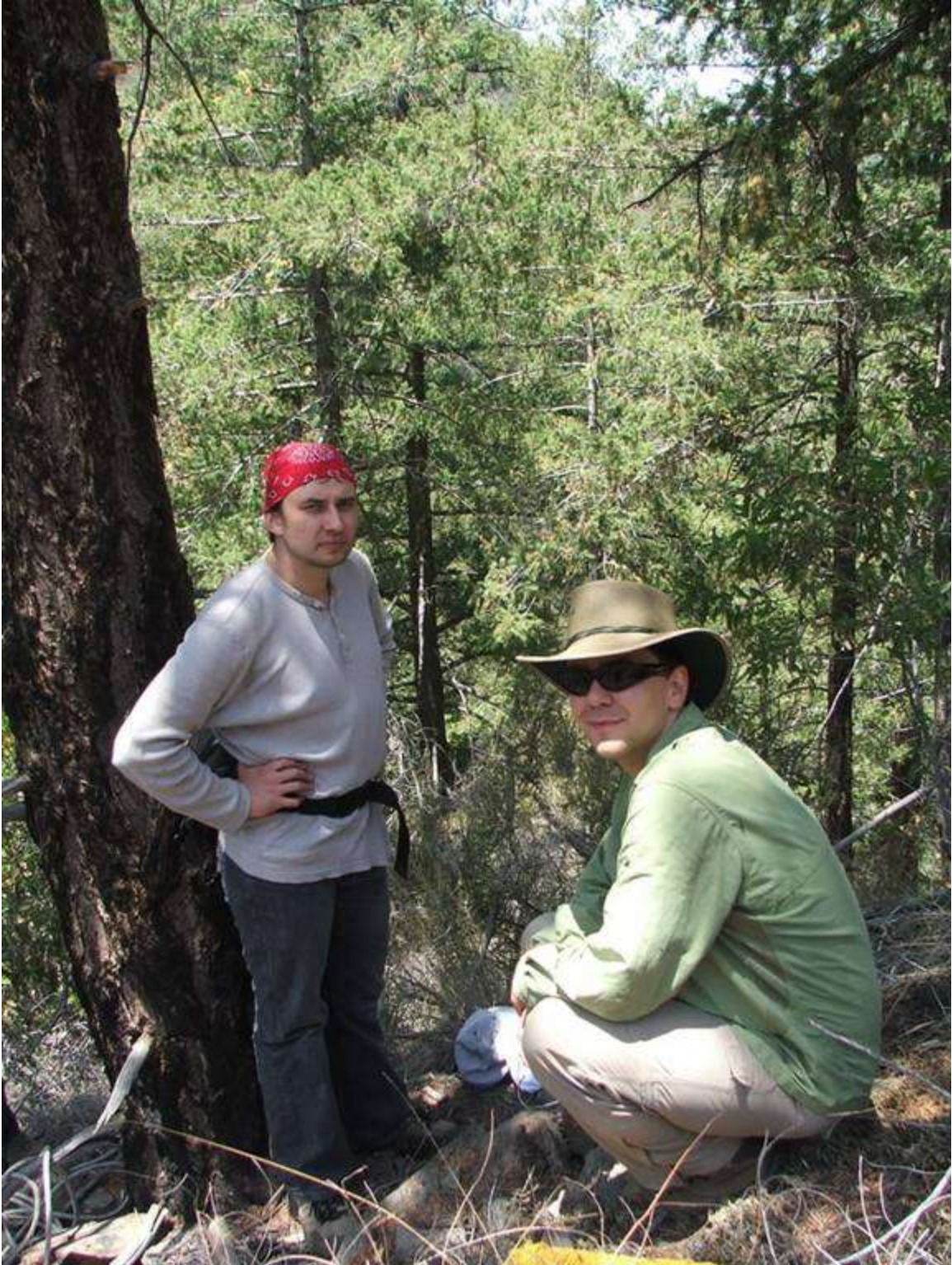


We found it on a previous hike but didn't feel safe crossing the chasm. We were prepared this time and after affixing a rope to a tree outside we sent the oldest unmarried male with fully paid life insurance (and therefore most expendable) across the affectionately nicknamed **Chasm of Doom** using the conveniently located (and half rotten) timbers.

Sadly at this point our visions of finding gold were shattered by the fact that once across the gap the shaft ended almost immediately after it went out of view.



Somewhat dejected at our lack of treasure we decided to make the best of things. We had brought a nice sized climbing rope all this way and we had an experienced rock climber among us so we decided rather than retracing our steps we would take the manly way out and climb directly to the trail a few hundred feet above.



We ate lunch at this small flat section among the ants and bugs who were being quite friendly by this time. (The dour faced Ukrainian is in the middle of expressing his dislike of climbing.)

We did some more exploring on the way out of the canyon but didn't find much else of interest.

Having emerged once again (relatively) unharmed from the wilderness we returned to Walter's pool area for beer, burgers, and planning of our next trip.